



EPIC OF KINGS

Flashcard Decks

Ancient Persian Facts, Words, and Legends

Print on regular paper, cut along the solid lines,
and fold along the dashed line so the term or fact is on one side
and its meaning or explanation on the back.

Ancient Persia: Government & Society

6 Cards

● GOVERNMENT & SOCIETY

The First Declaration of Human Rights

When the Persian ruler Cyrus the Great conquered Babylon in 539 BCE, he freed all the slaves and let everyone worship their own god. He wrote his decree on a clay cylinder called the Cyrus Cylinder. The United Nations recognizes the Cyrus Cylinder as one of the earliest declarations of human rights, and a replica of the legendary cylinder sits in the UN headquarters in New York City to this day.

● GOVERNMENT & SOCIETY

44% of the Entire World's Population

At its height, the Persian Empire was home to roughly 49 million people - about 44% of the entire world's population at that time. No empire before or since has ever ruled over such a large share of humanity.

● GOVERNMENT & SOCIETY

The World's First Monotheistic Religion

Zoroastrianism, founded by the Persian prophet Zoroaster around 1500 BCE, is widely considered the world's first monotheistic religion, meaning belief in one supreme God. Its core teaching is simple and profound: choose good thoughts, good words, and good deeds. This ancient Persian faith directly influenced Judaism, Christianity, and Islam. The Shahnameh is steeped in Zoroastrian values: the eternal battle between light and darkness runs through every page.

● GOVERNMENT & SOCIETY

The Tolerant Empire

Unlike most ancient empires, the Persian Empire let conquered peoples keep their languages, religions, and local leaders. Cyrus freed the Jews from Babylonian captivity and helped them rebuild their temple in Jerusalem. The Bible even calls Cyrus "the Lord's anointed."

Ancient Persia: Government & Society

6 Cards

● GOVERNMENT & SOCIETY

History's Ultimate Warrior Challenge

In the Shahnameh, before Rostam could rescue the king of Persia from the demon kingdom of Mazandaran, he had to survive seven impossible trials alone: a lion, a waterless desert, a dragon, a sorceress, a demon, a rushing river, and a final battle. Each trial tested a different quality: strength, endurance, cunning, and wisdom. The Seven Trials (Haft Khan) are the Shahnameh's greatest adventure sequence, comparable to the Twelve Labors of Hercules in Greek mythology. Except Rostam completed all seven in one journey.

● GOVERNMENT & SOCIETY

The Most Beautiful Ancient City Ever Built

Persepolis, the capital of ancient Persia, was so magnificent that when Alexander the Great conquered it in 330 BCE, his soldiers were reportedly stunned silent. The main audience hall had 72 columns, each 20 meters high. It took over 60 years to build.

Ancient Persia: Science & Innovation

8 Cards

● SCIENCE & INNOVATION

Ancient Persia Gave Us Algebra

The Persian mathematician al-Khwarizmi (800-850 CE) invented algebra. The word "algebra" comes from the title of his book. He also gave us the word "algorithm." Every math class in the world owes him a thank you!

● SCIENCE & INNOVATION

He Said the Earth Goes Around the Sun. 500 Years Early!

The Persian scholar Biruni suggested in the year 1000 CE that the Earth might rotate around the Sun, more than 500 years before Copernicus made the same claim in Europe! He also calculated the circumference of the Earth with remarkable accuracy using nothing but mathematics and careful observation.

● SCIENCE & INNOVATION

The Doctor Who Was 600 Years Ahead of His Time

A Persian doctor named Avicenna wrote a medical encyclopedia called The Canon of Medicine around 1025 CE. It became the standard medical textbook in Europe and the Middle East for over 600 years. He described how diseases spread through contaminated water and soil, centuries before anyone had heard of the word "germ"!

● SCIENCE & INNOVATION

Persians Invented the Refrigerator

Over 2,400 years ago, ancient Persians built underground domed structures that kept ice and food cold even in desert heat of 40°C. They called it a yakhchal ("yakh" means ice in Persian), and the word for refrigerator in Persian is still yakhchal today!

Ancient Persia: Science & Innovation

8 Cards

● SCIENCE & INNOVATION

The World's First Postal System

The Persians invented the "Chapar Khaneh" - a relay postal system with fresh horses stationed every 25 km across the empire. Herodotus wrote: "Neither snow nor rain nor heat nor darkness stops these couriers." Sound familiar? That's where the US Postal Service motto comes from!

● SCIENCE & INNOVATION

The World's First Windmill

Ancient Persians invented the world's first windmills around 500-900 CE, nearly 500 years before windmills appeared in Europe. These early windmills were used to grind grain and pump water, and their vertical-axis design was entirely Persian in origin. The wind that swept across the Persian plateau was put to work centuries before anyone else thought to try it!

● SCIENCE & INNOVATION

The Royal Road: The Ancient Internet

The Persian Empire built a 2,700 kilometer Royal Road stretching from Sardis (in modern Turkey) all the way to Susa in Persia. Using fresh horses stationed along the route, royal messengers could cover the entire distance in just 7 days with a journey that would take an ordinary traveler 90 days on foot! It was the fastest communication network the ancient world had ever seen, thousands of years before the internet! Pretty cool!

● SCIENCE & INNOVATION

Underground Water Engineers

Ancient Persians built "qanats" - underground aqueducts bringing water from distant mountains to desert cities. Some qanats were 70 km long and are still in use today, 3,000 years after they were built!

Ancient Persia: Culture & Language

7 Cards

● CULTURE & LANGUAGE

One of the Oldest Living Languages in the World

At over 2,500 years old, Persian, also known as Farsi, is one of the oldest continuously spoken languages in the world. Unlike Latin, which evolved into French, Spanish, and Italian and is no longer spoken as a living language. 130 million people speak Persian today in almost the same form as it was when Ferdowsi wrote the Shahnameh!

● CULTURE & LANGUAGE

The Persian Garden: Paradise on Earth

The English word "paradise" comes directly from the ancient Persian word "pardis," meaning a walled garden. Persian gardens were so breathtakingly beautiful, with flowing water, fruit trees, and geometric pathways, that they became the model for gardens across the ancient world, from the Hanging Gardens of Babylon to the gardens of the Mughal Empire in India.

● CULTURE & LANGUAGE

The World's Most-Read Poet Today

The best-selling poet in the United States today isn't American — he's a 13th-century Persian mystic named Rumi. His poems about love, God, and the human soul have been translated into dozens of languages and sell more copies in the US than any other poet. He lived 800 years ago and is still the world's most-read poet.

● CULTURE & LANGUAGE

Persia and Chess

The Persians are credited with spreading chess across the world. The words "checkmate" come from the Persian "Shah Mat" meaning "the king is dead." Every chess game echoes the Shahnameh.

Ancient Persia: Culture & Language

7 Cards

● CULTURE & LANGUAGE

Hafez: The Poet Every Iranian Knows by Heart

The poet Hafez was so gifted that he memorized the entire Quran as a young boy — that's how he got his name, which means "memorizer." He became the greatest lyric poet in Persian history, and today nearly every Iranian home has a copy of his collected poems. Iranians still use his visionary verses as everyday proverbs, almost like a second language.

● CULTURE & LANGUAGE

Nowruz: The World's Oldest New Year

The Persian New Year, called Nowruz, has been celebrated for over 3,000 years, making it the oldest New Year celebration still observed anywhere in the world today. It falls on the first day of spring and is celebrated by over 300 million people across Iran, Central Asia, and beyond. According to the Shahnameh, Nowruz was established by the legendary King Jamshid when he ascended to the heavens on a jeweled throne and the world filled with light.

● CULTURE & LANGUAGE

Shahnameh: The Epic That Saved a Language

The Shahnameh literally saved the Persian language. When Arab armies conquered Persia in 651 CE, Arabic began replacing Persian. Ferdowsi deliberately used pure Persian words with almost no Arabic when writing the Shahnameh. Because of Ferdowsi, Persian is still spoken by over 130 million people around the world.

Persian Words

55 Cards

● PERSIAN WORD

پهلوان

Pah-la-VAAN

Pahlavan

A champion warrior of extraordinary bravery, strength, and honor.
The greatest pahlavans are celebrated as protectors of Iran.

● PERSIAN WORD

فر

FARR

Farr

A divine radiance marking rightful kings and heroes. When a ruler loses the Farr, their kingdom falls. Sometimes shown as a sacred flame.

● PERSIAN WORD

شاهنامه

Shah-NAA-meh

Shahnameh

The "Book of Kings": the greatest epic poem in the Persian language, written by Ferdowsi over 30 years with over 50,000 verses.

● PERSIAN WORD

درفش

De-RAFSh

Derafsh

A royal battle banner. The most famous is the Derafsh Kaviani made from Kaveh the blacksmith's leather apron, which flew over the armies of Iran for generations.

Persian Words

55 Cards

● PERSIAN WORD

هفت خان

Haft-KHAAN

Haft Khan

The "Seven Trials": the legendary challenges Rostam overcomes on his journey to save the king. Each trial is more dangerous than the last.

● PERSIAN WORD

دادگر

daad-GAR

Dadgar

A just ruler who governs with fairness, wisdom, and compassion. Being called a dadgar king is the highest praise in the Shahnameh.

● PERSIAN WORD

گرز

GORZ

Gorz

A war mace: a heavy club weapon. Rostam's gorz was so heavy that no ordinary man could even lift it off the ground.

● PERSIAN WORD

تخت

TAKHT

Takht

A royal throne: the seat of kings. Seizing the Takht means taking power over an entire kingdom.

Persian Words

55 Cards

● PERSIAN WORD

تاج

TAAJ

Taj

A crown: the symbol of royal authority. The Taj is placed on a new king's head in solemn ceremonies, and its loss signals the fall of a kingdom.

● PERSIAN WORD

آتش

AA-tash

Atash

Fire: sacred in Persian tradition. Fire temples were holy places representing truth, purity, and divine presence in the Shahnameh.

● PERSIAN WORD

خورشید

Khor-SHEED

Khorshid

The sun: a symbol of glory and kingship. Great heroes and kings are compared to the Khorshid rising, bringing light to the world.

● PERSIAN WORD

ماه

MAAH

Mah

The moon: a symbol of beauty and mystery. Heroines are often compared to the full Mah shining in a dark sky.

Persian Words

55 Cards

● PERSIAN WORD

دریا

da-RYAA

Darya

The sea or a great river: a boundary between worlds. The Darya of the Oxus separates Iran from Turan.

● PERSIAN WORD

کوه

KOOH

Kuh

A mountain: a place of mystery and power. Mount Alborz is where the Simorgh lives; Mount Damavand is where Zakhak is imprisoned forever.

● PERSIAN WORD

جنگ

JANG

Jang

War or battle: the central drama of the Shahnameh. Great Jangs between Iran and Turan fill the epic with action and tragedy.

● PERSIAN WORD

صلح

SOLH

Solh

Peace: always precious and always fragile in the Shahnameh. Moments of Solh allow heroes to rest and people to flourish.

Persian Words

55 Cards

● PERSIAN WORD

عدل

ADL

Adl

Justice: one of the highest values in the Shahnameh. A king who upholds Adl will be remembered forever.

● PERSIAN WORD

دوستی

doos-TEE

Doosti

Friendship and loyalty: deeply important in the Shahnameh. The bonds of Doosti between warriors are tested in battle.

● PERSIAN WORD

دشمن

dosh-MAN

Doshman

An enemy or foe. The Shahnameh is full of great Doshmans: but even enemies can possess courage that heroes must respect.

● PERSIAN WORD

پیروزی

pee-ROO-zee

Piroozi

Victory: the reward for courage and perseverance. True Piroozi means upholding justice, not just defeating an enemy.

Persian Words

55 Cards

● PERSIAN WORD

شکست

she-KAST

Shekast

Defeat: how a hero responds to Shekast reveals their true character more than any victory ever could.

● PERSIAN WORD

نوروز

No-ROOZ

Nowruz

The Persian New Year, celebrated on the first day of spring. King Jamshid established Nowruz when he ascended to the sky on a jeweled throne. Still celebrated today!

● PERSIAN WORD

آرمان

Aar-MAAN

Arman

A noble ideal or aspiration: the dream of a better world that drives the Shahnameh's heroes forward.

● PERSIAN WORD

شجاعت

sho-JAA-at

Shejaat

Bravery or valor. Shejaat is not the absence of fear but the choice to act rightly despite it.

Persian Words

55 Cards

● PERSIAN WORD

خرد

khe-RAD

Kherad

Wisdom and reason: prized above all qualities. A hero with great Kherad can find solutions that brute strength never could.

● PERSIAN WORD

راستی

raas-TEE

Rasti

Truthfulness and righteousness: a core virtue. Rasti means living honestly and in alignment with what is right.

● PERSIAN WORD

آزادی

Aa-ZAA-dee

Azadi

Freedom: what the heroes of the Shahnameh ultimately fight for. Liberation from tyrants like Zahhak is the great theme of the epic.

● PERSIAN WORD

افتخار

Ef-te-KHAAR

Eftekhar

Pride and honor: the dignity warriors protect above all things. To lose one's Eftekhar is worse than death for a true pahlavan.

Persian Words

55 Cards

● PERSIAN WORD

دل

DEL

Del

The heart: the center of courage, love, and feeling in Persian poetry.
A great Del means brave, passionate, and full of life.

● PERSIAN WORD

جان

JAAN

Jan

The soul or life-force: the divine spark within every living being.
Heroes willingly risk their Jan for Iran, justice, and the people they love.

● PERSIAN WORD

آب

AAB

Ab

Water: life-giving and important throughout the Shahnameh. Great rivers and oases shape battles and journeys.

● PERSIAN WORD

باد

BAAD

Bad

Wind: often invoked to describe speed and freedom. "Swift as the Bad" is high praise for a warrior or horse.

Persian Words

55 Cards

● PERSIAN WORD

زمین

Za-MEEN

Zamin

The earth or land: something precious and worth protecting. Heroes shed blood to defend their Zamin from invaders.

● PERSIAN WORD

آسمان

Aas-MAAN

Aseman

The sky or heavens: the realm of divine power and fate. The Aseman rewards the just and punishes the wicked.

● PERSIAN WORD

ستاره

Se-TAA-reh

Setareh

A star: signs of fate and prophecy. Wise astrologers read the Setareh to predict the births of heroes and the outcomes of battles.

● PERSIAN WORD

شب

SHAB

Shab

Night: a time of danger and great deeds. Many of the most dramatic Shahnameh moments happen in the darkness of Shab.

Persian Words

55 Cards

● PERSIAN WORD

روز

ROOZ

Rooz

Day: the time of action, glory, and decision. "The Rooz of battle" means the decisive moment when everything is at stake.

● PERSIAN WORD

گنج

GANJ

Ganj

Treasure: the epic teaches that the greatest treasure is not gold but courage, loyalty, and wisdom.

● PERSIAN WORD

دژ

DEZH

Dezh

A fortress or stronghold. Many great Shahnameh stories involve heroes besieging or escaping from a fearsome Dezh.

● PERSIAN WORD

لشکر

LASH-kar

Lashkar

An army: the great forces that clash across the Shahnameh's battlefields. When the king falls, the Lashkar scatters like leaves.

Persian Words

55 Cards

● PERSIAN WORD

زره

Zeh-REH

Zereh

Armor: the protective covering worn by warriors. The finest Zereh in the Shahnameh is crafted by master smiths and may be enchanted.

● PERSIAN WORD

کمان

Ka-MAAN

Kaman

A bow: one of the great weapons of the Shahnameh. Persian archers were among the finest in the ancient world.

● PERSIAN WORD

تیر

TEER

Tir

An arrow: swift, precise, and deadly. The Tir appears in some of the most dramatic moments, deciding battles with a single shot.

● PERSIAN WORD

اسب

ASB

Asb

A horse: essential to every Shahnameh warrior. A great Asb like Rakhsh is almost as famous as its rider.

Persian Words

55 Cards

● PERSIAN WORD

پر

PAR

Par

A feather: specifically the magical feather of the Simorgh that Zal carries. By burning a Par, he can call the great bird to his aid.

● PERSIAN WORD

آهنگر

Aa-han-GAR

Ahangar

A blacksmith who works with iron and fire. In the Shahnameh, the blacksmith Kaveh becomes a hero by standing up to the tyrant Zahhak.

● PERSIAN WORD

پادشاه

Paa-de-SHAAH

Padshah

A king or great ruler. The Shahnameh judges every Padshah by how they treat their people.

● PERSIAN WORD

وزیر

Va-ZEER

Vazir

A royal advisor. In the Shahnameh, a good Vazir can save a kingdom; a bad one can destroy it.

Persian Words

55 Cards

● PERSIAN WORD

شاعر

shaa-ER

Shaer

A poet: the keeper of memory and truth. Ferdowsi was a Shaer who believed poetry could preserve a civilization forever.

● PERSIAN WORD

دانش

daa-NESH

Danesh

Knowledge and learning: treasured in Persian culture. The Shahnameh honors heroes who are wise as well as brave.

● PERSIAN WORD

امید

o-MEED

Omid

Hope: the quality that keeps heroes going through defeat and darkness. Without Omid, no journey can be completed.

● PERSIAN WORD

نام

NAAM

Nam

Name and reputation: one of the most sacred concepts in the Shahnameh. A hero lives and dies for their Nam. To lose one's Nam is worse than death itself.

Persian Words

55 Cards

● PERSIAN WORD

پیمان

pay-MAAN

Peyman

Covenant or sacred oath. In the Shahnameh, breaking a Peyman is one of the gravest acts a hero or king can commit. Oaths bind warriors, seal alliances between kingdoms, and define the moral code of the epic.

● PERSIAN WORD

بزم

BAZM

Bazm

A royal feast or celebration: the joyful twin of Razm (battle). The Shahnameh moves constantly between Bazm and Razm: heroes who fight by day feast by night, and a great king is judged by how he holds both.

● PERSIAN WORD

رزم

RAZM

Razm

Battle or combat. Razm is the central arena of the Shahnameh. Great Razms between Persia and Turan, between heroes and demons, between kings and rivals define the arc of the entire epic. Where there is Razm, there is fate.

Legends: Kings

12 Cards

● KING

Kiumars

The very first king in the Shahnameh, Kiumars is the founding father of human civilization. He taught humanity to cook food, make clothes from animal skins, and live together in society. In the Shahnameh's telling, human history begins with Kiumars, making him the Persian equivalent of Adam. His reign was tragically cut short when Ahriman's son killed his beloved son Siamak.

● KING

Siamak

The son of the first king Kiumars, Siamak was a brave prince who died fighting Ahriman's demon son in the world's very first great battle between good and evil. His death devastated Kiumars but also sparked the first war of vengeance in human history. Siamak's son Hooshang would avenge him.

● KING

Hooshang

The grandson of Kiumars who avenged his father Siamak's murder and became one of the greatest civilizing kings in the Shahnameh. Hooshang discovered fire by accidentally striking two stones together, taught humanity to work iron and steel, built irrigation systems, and established the festival of Sadeh. He is one of the great culture-heroes of Persian mythology.

● KING

Tahmorris

The king known as "the Div-Binder" who captured demons and forced them to teach humanity the art of writing. Tahmorris subdued Ahriman himself and rode him across the world like a horse. He is credited with introducing thirty scripts to humanity. His reign represents the triumph of human civilization over supernatural evil through cunning and strength.

Legends: Kings

12 Cards

● KING

Jamshid

One of the greatest kings in the Shahnameh, Jamshid ruled for centuries and brought civilization to humanity. He invented iron, taught the crafts of weaving and medicine, and established the festival of Nowruz. But when he declared himself a god, the divine Farr (royal glory) abandoned him, and Zahhak rose to overthrow him.

● KING

Fereydun

The hero-king who overthrew Zahhak with Kaveh's help. Fereydun bound Zahhak in chains beneath Mount Damavand and ruled Persia wisely for centuries. His greatest mistake was dividing his kingdom among his three sons, which led to tragedy, betrayal, and the murder of his most virtuous son Iraj.

● KING

Manucehr

One of the great early kings of the Shahnameh, Manucehr was the king who avenged the murder of Iraj and restored justice to Persia. He was a strong and wise ruler who helped establish the heroic tradition that would eventually produce Rostam. The legendary Sam and Zal both served under his reign.

● KING

Sam

The great champion Sam was one of the mightiest warriors of his age and the father of the white-haired Zal. When Zal was born with snow-white hair, Sam was convinced it was an evil omen and abandoned the infant on a mountaintop. He later repented and was reunited with his son. Sam served multiple kings faithfully and his family line produced Rostam, the greatest hero of the Shahnameh.

Legends: Kings

12 Cards

● KING

Kay Kavus

One of the more complex kings of the Shahnameh, Kay Kavus was brave but often reckless and vain. He attempted to fly to heaven using eagles, was captured by a demon king, and repeatedly placed Persia in danger through his foolishness. Yet he was also capable of great kingship, and Rostam faithfully served and rescued him time and again.

● KING

Kay Khosrow

One of the greatest and most virtuous kings of the Shahnameh, Kay Khosrow was the son of the martyred Siavash and grandson of Kay Kavus. He united Persia and Turan, avenged his father's murder by defeating Afrasiyab, and then made the extraordinary decision to abdicate at the height of his power rather than risk becoming corrupted by it. He simply walked away from his throne and disappeared into legend.

● KING

Lohrasp

The king who succeeded the legendary Kay Khosrow after his mysterious disappearance. Lohrasp was a just and capable ruler who established his dynasty and helped maintain the peace that Kay Khosrow had won. His son Goshtasp would become one of the most significant kings of the later Shahnameh.

● KING

Goshtasp

King Goshtasp was the father of the mighty Esfandiyar and the king who embraced Zoroastrianism and spread its teachings across Persia. His reign marks a pivotal spiritual turning point in the Shahnameh. Yet he was also responsible for sending his own son Esfandiyar on a mission that led to tragedy, making him one of the epic's more morally complex royal figures.

Legends: Heroes

16 Cards

● HERO

Kaveh

A humble blacksmith who became one of the greatest symbols of justice in Persian history. When Zahhak's soldiers came to take his sons to feed the serpents, Kaveh refused and raised his leather apron as a banner of revolt. This apron, the Derafsh Kaviani, became the royal banner of Persia for centuries. Kaveh proves that the greatest heroes are not always kings.

● HERO

Iraj

The youngest and most beloved of Fereydun's three sons. When his brothers Salm and Tur demanded his portion of the kingdom, Iraj chose to give it up willingly rather than go to war. His brothers murdered him anyway. His death is one of the purest tragedies in the Shahnameh, a man killed for his own virtue, and set off generations of vengeance.

● HERO

Zal

Born with snow-white hair, Zal was abandoned by his father Sam on a mountaintop because of his unusual appearance. He was raised by the mythical Simorgh. When he eventually reunited with his father and fell in love with Rudabeh, he became one of the wisest counselors in Persia. Father of the great Rostam.

● HERO

Rudabeh

The beautiful princess who fell in love with the silver-haired Zal against all custom and convention. Rudabeh's courage in pursuing love despite her family's opposition is remarkable. When Zal climbed to her tower, she let down her own hair as a rope for him to climb. She later became the mother of Rostam.

Legends: Heroes

16 Cards

● HERO

Rostam

The greatest hero of the Shahnameh and arguably the most powerful warrior in all of Persian mythology. Son of Zal and Rudabeh, Rostam's life spans hundreds of years and countless battles. He completed the legendary Seven Trials (Haft Khan), slew dragons and demons, and served as the shield of Persia through multiple dynasties. His horse Rakhsh was as legendary as Rostam himself.

● HERO

Rakhsh

Rostam's legendary horse and faithful companion. Only Rostam was strong enough to ride Rakhsh; any other rider would have been crushed. Rakhsh was fiercely devoted to Rostam, even saving his life during the Seven Trials by killing a lion while Rostam slept. A hero in his own right.

● HERO

Tahmineh

The princess who sought out Rostam in the night, drawn by his legendary reputation. She became his secret wife and the mother of Sohrab. Tahmineh raised Sohrab alone, telling him his father was dead to protect him. Her choice, made out of love and fear, set in motion the tragedy of Sohrab's death at Rostam's hands.

● HERO

Sohrab

The tragic son of Rostam who grew up not knowing his father's identity. Sohrab became a great warrior and set out to find Rostam. Their eventual meeting in battle — neither knowing the other's identity — results in one of the most heartbreaking moments in world literature. Rostam kills his own son before learning the truth.

Legends: Heroes

16 Cards

● HERO

Gordafarid

One of the few female warriors in the Shahnameh, Gordafarid was a Persian noblewoman who donned armor and rode into battle against Sohrab when no male warrior would face him. She fought brilliantly, held her own against the mighty Sohrab, and used cunning to escape when she was finally unhorsed. Her name means "born of heroes" and she embodies the Shahnameh's recognition that heroism knows no gender.

● HERO

Piran

The most honorable general in all of Turan. Piran served Afrasiyab faithfully but never lost his conscience. He sheltered Siavash when he fled to Turan, arranged his marriage, and later raised the infant Kay Khosrow in hiding to protect him from Afrasiyab. Despite fighting on the wrong side of history, Piran acted with more decency than most men on either side of the conflict.

● HERO

Siavash

A prince of extraordinary beauty and virtue, Siavash is one of the most tragic figures in the Shahnameh. Falsely accused by his stepmother, he proved his innocence by riding through fire unharmed. He later chose exile and death over dishonor. His murder at the hands of Afrasiyab sparked one of the great wars of the epic. His name means "black horse" in Old Persian.

● HERO

Gudarz

One of the greatest Persian generals in the Shahnameh. Gudarz served multiple kings across generations, commanding armies in the most important battles against Turan. He led a vast family of warrior sons devoted to Persia's defense. His son Giv embarked on one of the most remarkable quests in the epic: seven years searching alone through Turan to find the hidden prince Kay Khosrow and bring him home.

Legends: Heroes

16 Cards

● HERO

Bizhan

A young Persian hero who fell into the trap of Afrasiyab after entering Turan in secret to hunt wild boars. Imprisoned in a deep well sealed with a great stone, he was only freed when Rostam came to his rescue after Manijeh revealed his location. His story is one of love, adventure, and the power of loyalty.

● HERO

Manijeh

A princess who fell deeply in love with the Persian hero Bizhan and helped rescue him from imprisonment in a well. When her father Afrasiyab discovered her love for a Persian, she was cast out and forced to beg for bread to feed the imprisoned Bizhan. Her devotion eventually helped bring about his rescue by Rostam.

● HERO

Esfandiyar

A prince made nearly invincible through divine blessing, Esfandiyar was one of the mightiest warriors in the Shahnameh. Only his eyes could be pierced. His tragic conflict with Rostam is one of the most moving episodes in the epic: two great heroes forced into battle neither wanted, with devastating consequences. His story is a meditation on duty, fate, and the cost of ambition.

● HERO

Ferdowsi

The great Persian poet who spent thirty years composing the Shahnameh, the longest epic poem ever written by a single author. Ferdowsi devoted his life to preserving ancient Persian stories in verse. When Sultan Mahmud received the completed work, he paid a fraction of what he had promised. Ferdowsi died in near-poverty, but the Shahnameh has outlasted every king who ever slighted him.

Legends: Villains

7 Cards

● VILLAIN

Ahriman

The great spirit of evil and darkness in Zoroastrian mythology, Ahriman is the cosmic opposite of Ahura Mazda, the supreme god of goodness. In the Shahnameh, Ahriman works through corruption and deception rather than direct confrontation. It was Ahriman who corrupted the young Zahhak, kissing his shoulders and causing the serpents to grow. Ahriman represents the eternal battle between light and darkness that runs through the entire epic.

● VILLAIN

Zahhak

The most fearsome tyrant in the Shahnameh. Zahhak was corrupted by the evil spirit Ahriman, who kissed his shoulders and caused two serpents to grow from them. The serpents demanded to be fed human brains every day. Zahhak ruled Persia for a thousand years of darkness until the blacksmith Kaveh rose against him and the hero Fereyduh ended his reign.

● VILLAIN

Salm and Tur

The two elder sons of Fereyduh and the murderers of their own brother Iraj. When their father divided his kingdom, Iraj received the greatest portion. When Iraj surrendered it willingly to keep the peace, Salm and Tur killed him anyway. Their crime set off the cycle of vengeance that echoes through generations of the Shahnameh.

● VILLAIN

Afrasiyab

The great king of Turan and Persia's most enduring enemy. Afrasiyab was cunning, powerful, and ruthless, ordering the murder of the innocent Siavash. His conflict with Persia spans generations of the Shahnameh and drives many of its central conflicts. Despite his evil acts, the Shahnameh portrays him with a certain tragic grandeur.

Legends: Villains

7 Cards

● VILLAIN

Sudabeh

The queen of Persia and wife of Kay Kavus. Sudabeh became dangerously obsessed with her stepson Siavash and, when he rejected her, falsely accused him before the king. Her lie forced Siavash to prove his innocence by riding through fire, ultimately driving him into the exile that cost him his life.

● VILLAIN

Garsivaz

Garsivaz was the brother of Afrasiyab and one of the most poisonous schemers in the Shahnameh. When the noble prince Siavash found peace and safety in Turan, Garsivaz grew jealous and whispered lies into Afrasiyab's ear, convincing the king that Siavash was a threat. His scheming led directly to the murder of the innocent Siavash, a crime that plunged Iran and Turan into generations of revenge. Garsivaz is the villain whose words, not his sword, did the deadliest damage.

● VILLAIN

Shoghad

The treacherous half-brother of Rostam and one of the most despised figures in the entire Shahnameh. Shoghad conspired with the king of Kabul to dig a well of iron spikes to trap and kill Rostam. Even mortally wounded, Rostam had the strength to pin Shoghad to a walnut tree with his final arrow. Shoghad represents the ultimate betrayal: a brother's jealousy destroying the greatest hero Persia ever produced.

Legends: Creatures

6 Cards

● CREATURE

Zahhak's Serpents

The two serpents that grew from Zahhak's shoulders after Ahriman kissed him. They could only be soothed by being fed human brains every day. The serpents became a symbol of tyranny consuming its own people. Even after Zahhak was overthrown, he was not killed. Instead he was chained in a cave beneath Mount Damavand, where legend says he waits still.

● CREATURE

Simorgh

The mythical bird of Persian legend, ancient beyond measure and wise beyond all creatures. The Simorgh lived on Mount Qaf at the edge of the world and possessed all the knowledge of the ages. She raised the infant Zal when his father abandoned him, and later helped both Zal and Rostam in their greatest trials. Her feather, when burned, would summon her instantly.

● CREATURE

The White Div

The king of the demons of Mazandaran, the White Div was the most powerful creature Rostam faced in his Seven Trials. Rostam needed the White Div's blood to restore the sight of Kay Kavus and his blinded army. The battle between Rostam and the White Div is one of the most dramatic in the Shahnameh.

● CREATURE

Azhdaha

The great dragon of Persian mythology, the Azhdaha appears throughout the Shahnameh as one of the ultimate tests of heroic courage. These massive serpentine creatures breathe fire and possess supernatural strength. Rostam slays a dragon during his Seven Trials, and dragons appear guarding ancient treasures and sacred places. The Azhdaha represents chaos, destruction, and the primal forces that heroes must overcome to prove their worth.

Legends: Creatures

6 Cards

● CREATURE

Akvan Div

Akvan Div was a monstrous demon who found Rostam sleeping in a meadow. He lifted the entire patch of earth Rostam lay on and carried it into the sky, then offered the hero a cruel choice: be thrown onto the mountains or into the sea. Rostam, knowing that a div always does the opposite of what it is asked, begged to be hurled at the mountains, so Akvan threw him into the sea, where Rostam survived and swam to shore. It is one of the cleverest escapes in the whole epic.

● CREATURE

Homa Bird

The Homa (also called Huma) is a sacred mythical bird in Persian tradition whose shadow falling upon a person confers royalty and great fortune. The bird never lands on earth but flies eternally through the heavens. Persian kings were sometimes said to rule because the Homa's shadow had blessed them. The Homa represents divine favor, destiny, and the sacred connection between heaven and earthly kingship.

Legends: Places

15 Cards

● PLACE

Iran

Iran is the heartland of the Shahnameh, the homeland the heroes spend the entire epic defending. It is the land of just kings and mighty champions, blessed with the divine farr, the royal glory that marks rightful rule. Almost every battle in the epic is ultimately about protecting Iran and its people from the forces of chaos and tyranny. To Ferdowsi, Iran was not just a place but an idea worth a thousand years of struggle.

● PLACE

Mount Damavand

The great volcanic mountain that stands at the heart of Persian mythology. Mount Damavand is where Fereydun chained the tyrant Zakhak in a cave for eternity. It is the highest peak in Iran and the Middle East, and has been a symbol of Persian identity and resistance for thousands of years. Persians still point to it as the guardian of their homeland.

● PLACE

Alborz Mountains

The great mountain range that runs across northern Persia, the Alborz is one of the most sacred and dramatic landscapes in the Shahnameh. It is where Zal was abandoned as an infant and raised by the Simorgh. Its highest peak, Mount Damavand, is where the tyrant Zakhak is chained for eternity. The Alborz stands as a boundary between the human world and the realm of myth.

● PLACE

Kabul

The ancient city of Kabul plays a pivotal role in the Shahnameh as the home of Rudabeh, the princess who became Rostam's mother. Her father Mehrab was a descendant of the tyrant Zakhak, making Rostam's birth a merging of the darkest and brightest bloodlines in Persian mythology. Kabul represents the complex, interconnected world of the Shahnameh, where enemies and heroes share the same roots.

Legends: Places

15 Cards

● PLACE

Zabulistan and Sistan

The homeland of Rostam and the legendary Sam dynasty, Zabulistan and Sistan form the heartland of Persian heroic tradition.

This rugged southeastern region is where Zal was born with his white hair, where Sam trained his warriors, and where Rostam grew up to become the greatest champion in Persian history. The city of Zabul was their seat of power and the source of the mightiest heroes the Shahnameh has ever known.

● PLACE

Mazandaran

The demon-haunted kingdom of Mazandaran is one of the most fearsome realms in the Shahnameh. When King Kay Kavus foolishly led his army there, the White Div blinded them all with black magic. It fell to Rostam to undertake his legendary Seven Trials to reach Mazandaran, defeat its demons, and restore sight to the blinded king and his army. Deep within Mazandaran stood the White Castle, the stronghold of the White Div, and it was there that Rostam fought his most terrible battle.

● PLACE

Samangan

Samangan is the city where one of the epic's greatest tragedies begins. After Rostam loses his horse Rakhsh near its borders, he is welcomed as a guest by the king of Samangan, and there he meets and marries the princess Tahmineh. From this brief union comes their son Sohrab, the boy who will one day face his own father in battle without either knowing the other. Samangan is where a love story plants the seed of heartbreak.

● PLACE

Hamavaran

Hamavaran was a kingdom by the sea whose king pretended to surrender to Kay Kavus, then treacherously captured him and his champions in a trap. It was also the homeland of Sudabeh, the king's daughter, who fell in love with Kay Kavus and chose to share his imprisonment. Rostam had to march to Hamavaran and break the king's power to free his captured ruler. The kingdom is remembered for both betrayal and a daughter's devotion.

Legends: Places

15 Cards

● PLACE

Turan

The great kingdom to the north and east of Persia, Turan is Persia's eternal rival throughout the Shahnameh. Ruled for centuries by the cunning king Afrasiyab, Turan and Persia clash in wars that span generations. Many of the Shahnameh's greatest heroes cross the border into Turan and many of its greatest tragedies unfold there, including the murder of the virtuous prince Siavash.

● PLACE

Oxus River

The mighty Oxus River, known in Persian as the Jeyhun, is the great border between Iran and Turan. For generation after generation, armies crossed this river to make war, and heroes forded it on secret missions. When Siavash was exiled, he crossed the Oxus into Turan. The river is the dividing line that shapes the whole geography of the epic, the edge where the world of the heroes ends and the land of the enemy begins.

● PLACE

Gang Dezh

Gang Dezh was a legendary fortress-city built by the exiled prince Siavash in the land of Turan, a place of beauty and safety far from his enemies. After Siavash was murdered, the fortress passed into the story of his son Kay Khosrow, becoming a symbol of the paradise that was lost when the innocent prince was killed. Gang Dezh stands in the epic as a reminder of what might have been, a perfect city built by a doomed and gentle hero.

● PLACE

Balkh

Balkh was one of the most ancient and important cities of the Persian world, sometimes called the mother of cities. In the Shahnameh it is the seat of King Goshtasp, and it is closely tied to the coming of the prophet Zoroaster and the new faith he brought to Iran. Balkh is where religion, kingship, and the great deeds of heroes like Esfandiyar come together in the later age of the epic.

Legends: Places

15 Cards

● PLACE

Persepolis

The magnificent ceremonial capital of the Persian Empire, built by Darius the Great around 515 BCE. Persepolis was a wonder of the ancient world, with grand staircases, towering columns, and intricate carvings depicting scenes of tribute from across the empire. Alexander the Great burned it in 330 BCE. Its ruins still stand in modern Iran, a testament to Persian civilization.

● PLACE

Rum (Rome)

In the world of the Shahnameh, Rum refers to the Byzantine Roman Empire to the west. Persian kings and heroes occasionally deal with the rulers of Rum in diplomacy and war. The inclusion of Rum in the Shahnameh reflects the ancient Persian awareness of the broader civilized world. Persia saw itself as the center of the world, with Rum to the west, Chin (China) to the east, and Turan to the north.

● PLACE

Chin (China)

In the Shahnameh, Chin refers to China, the great empire at the eastern edge of the known world. Persian kings and heroes occasionally interact with the ruler of Chin, reflecting ancient Persia's awareness of the Silk Road civilizations beyond its borders. The Shahnameh portrays a world where Persia stands at the center, with Rum (Rome) to the west, Turan to the north, and Chin to the east, a remarkable vision of the ancient connected world.